> China has time on its side, as the deadline set by Xi for achieving the Chinese dream is 2049; in reality, Xi's China is becoming more and more impatient to regain control over the island. . . . Xi himself has potentially set the clock ticking on unification, stating in a speech early in 2019 that the Taiwan problem could not be passed down from "generation to generation." . . . In a landmark speech in January 2019, Xi lauded the "one country, two systems" model used in Hong Kong for Taiwan.[5]

Yet only ten percent of Taiwanese support unification with the mainland, according to opinion polls, and that share is largely accounted for by PRC-born residents. A paradoxical feature of the past decade has been the fact that, contrary to Beijing's expectations, "the closer the two economies grew, the more people identified as Taiwanese rather than Chinese, and the less open they have become to rule from Beijing."[6] The storm of protest unleashed in Hong Kong by an ill-advised extradition bill, and the response of the government in Beijing, has only increased the antipathy of Taiwanese voters to the idea of submitting to a status equivalent to Hong Kong's.

Auslin's most explosive chapter is his last. "The Sino-American Littoral War of 2025: A Future History" imagines the dire consequences of what he sees as the American failure to maintain a proper alignment between ends and means in the Asian Mediterranean. In this speculative scenario, which is evidently informed by recent Department of Defense war games, Auslin imagines an escalation of the Sino-American antagonism into a full-scale conventional naval war, culminating in the sinking of the USS *Gerald R. Ford*, the newest and biggest of American aircraft carriers, which was formally commissioned by President Trump in July 2017.

In this vision, it is the first year of a new Democratic administration. Nothing in (by implication) the second Trump term has reduced the antagonism between Beijing and Washington. When President Newsom—who would certainly not be the first governor of California